Chapter 21 — Cheat Sheets and Glossary

This last chapter compresses Chapters 1–20 into pages you can scan in a minute: one-page **cheat sheets** by topic, a **"which tool for which job"** table, and an alphabetical **glossary** of 560+ terms, each pointing to the section where it is explained properly. Nothing here is new — if a line doesn't make sense, follow its section reference (written like **§6.2** = Chapter 6, section 2) back to the full explanation.

> **New to a word?** Every term, acronym and tool name used in this book — from *API*, *CLI* and *PATH* to *GIL*, *DAG* and *Copy-on-Write* — has a one-line plain-English definition in the glossary (21.22). Words about networks and large systems (HTTP, latency, caching, queues) are explained in more depth in System Design Fundamentals.

Every snippet with a visible result was checked by `code/cheatsheet_checks.py` (Python 3.14; all 10 checks pass; everything shown is valid on 3.12 unless a version is noted). Each sheet's heading names the chapters it compresses.

Chapter links: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4 · 5 · 6 · 7 · 8 · 9 · 10 · 11 · 12 · 13 · 14 · 15 · 16 · 17 · 18 · 19 · 20

21.1 Syntax and control flow (§1.9–1.11, Ch 3)

Concept	Syntax / rule
Blocks	A line ending in `:` opens a block; its body is indented **4 spaces**; no braces (§1.9)
Comments / docstrings	`# comment` (discarded); `"""Docstring."""` as the first statement → `__doc__` (§1.10)
Line continuation	Implicit inside `()`, `[]`, `{}`; avoid backslashes (§1.9)
Names	Case-sensitive; `snake_case` variables/functions, `CapWords` classes, `UPPER_CASE` constants (§1.11)
Input / output	`input(prompt)` always returns `str`; `print(*values, sep=" ", end="\n")` (§1.7, §1.9)
Script entry point	`if __name__ == "__main__": main()` (§8.5)
`if`	`if c1: … elif c2: … else: …` — first truthy branch wins (§3.2)
Conditional expression	`x = a if cond else b` (§3.3)
`match` (3.10+)	`match cmd:` / `case "quit": …` / `case ["go", direction]: …` / `case {"id": id_}:` / `case Point(x=0):` / `case _:` — no fall-through; bare names **capture** (§3.4)
`for`	`for x in iterable:` — any iterable; `range(start, stop, step)` stop excluded (§3.6)
`while`	`while cond:`; `while True: … break` for loop-and-a-half (§3.7)
Loop control	`break` (leave innermost loop), `continue` (next iteration), `pass` (do nothing) (§3.8)
Loop `else`	Runs only if the loop finished **without** `break` (§3.9)
Walrus	`while (line := f.readline()):` — assign inside an expression, 3.8+ (§2.8)

```
for i, name in enumerate(names, start=1):      # index + value
for a, b in zip(xs, ys, strict=True):          # parallel, error on length mismatch
for k, v in d.items():                          # dict pairs
for x in reversed(seq): ...                     # backwards
for x in sorted(xs, key=len): ...               # sorted view, original unchanged
```

Zen and style: PEP 20 (`import this`) — readability counts, explicit beats implicit, errors shouldn't pass silently. PEP 8 is the style guide; let a formatter (Black/Ruff) apply it (§1.11).

21.2 Types, numbers and operators (Ch 2)

Type	Example	Mutable?	Notes
`int`	`42`, `0b101`, `0xff`, `1_000_000`	no	unbounded precision (§2.5)
`float`	`3.14`, `1e-3`, `float("inf")`	no	IEEE-754 double, ~15–17 significant digits (§2.5)
`complex`	`2 + 3j`	no	`.real`, `.imag`
`bool`	`True`, `False`	no	subclass of `int` (`True + 1 == 2`) (§2.6)
`str`	`"hi"`, `'hi'`, `"""multi"""`, `r"\d"`, `f"{x}"`	no	Unicode text (Ch 4)
`bytes` / `bytearray`	`b"\x00"`	no / yes	raw binary (§4.9)
`list`	`[1, "a"]`	yes	dynamic array (Ch 5)
`tuple`	`(1, 2)`, `1, 2`, `(1,)`	no	the comma makes the tuple (§5.9)
`range`	`range(0, 10, 2)`	no	lazy sequence
`dict`	`{"k": 1}`	yes	insertion-ordered (Ch 6)
`set` / `frozenset`	`{1, 2}`, `set()`	yes / no	`{}` is an empty **`dict`** (§6.6)
`NoneType`	`None`	no	the single "no value" object; test with `is None`

Falsy values: `None`, `False`, `0`, `0.0`, `0j`, `Decimal(0)`, `Fraction(0)`, `""`, `[]`, `()`, `{}`, `set()`, `range(0)`. Everything else is truthy (§2.6).

Conversions (§2.7): `int("42")`, `int("ff", 16)`, `int(3.9) → 3` (truncates), `float("1.5")`, `str(3)`, `bool([]) → False`, `list("ab") → ['a', 'b']`, `ord("A") → 65`, `chr(65) → 'A'`. Bad input raises `ValueError`; wrong type raises `TypeError`.

Operators (§2.8):

Kind	Operators	Watch out
Arithmetic	`+ - * / // % **`	`/` always float; `//` floors (`-7 // 2 == -4`); `%` takes the divisor's sign (`-7 % 3 == 2`); `**` is right-associative and binds tighter than unary minus (`-2 ** 2 == -4`)
Comparison	`== != < <= > >=`, chains `0 < x < 10`	compare floats with `math.isclose`
Identity / membership	`is`, `is not`, `in`, `not in`	`is` only for `None`/singletons
Logical	`and`, `or`, `not`	short-circuit; return an **operand** (`"" or "x" → 'x'`)
Bitwise	`& | ^ ~ << >>`	`~x == -x - 1`
Assignment	`=`, `+=` …, `:=`	`+=` mutates lists in place, rebinds immutables
Built-in maths	`abs`, `round` (half-to-even: `round(2.5) == 2`), `divmod`, `pow(b, e, m)`, `min`, `max`, `sum`	

Money and exactness: `Decimal("0.1")` (from a string!) for money, `Fraction(1, 3)` for exact ratios, `math.isclose` for float comparison (§2.5, §14.8).

21.3 Data structures and big-O (§5.3, §6.2, §6.12, §17.5, §19.1)

Structure	Use for	Fast (avg)	Slow
`list`	ordered, growable sequence	`a[i]`, `a[i]=x`, `append`, `pop()` → O(1)	`insert(0,x)`, `pop(0)`, `x in a`, `remove`, `index` → O(n)
`tuple`	fixed record, dict key	`t[i]` O(1)	no mutation
`dict`	key → value	`d[k]`, `d[k]=v`, `del d[k]`, `k in d` → O(1)	worst case O(n) with collisions
`set`	uniqueness, membership	`add`, `discard`, `x in s` → O(1)	no indexing
`collections.deque`	queue / both-ends stack / last N	`append`, `appendleft`, `pop`, `popleft` → O(1)	middle index O(n)
`heapq` on a list	priority queue, top-k	push/pop O(log n), peek `h[0]` O(1), `heapify` O(n)	search O(n)
`bisect` on a sorted list	ordered search	search O(log n)	`insort` O(n)
`array.array`	compact numbers	O(1) index	Python-level maths not faster
`numpy.ndarray`	numeric arrays	vectorised maths in C	appending is O(n) (copies)

Operation	Cost	Operation	Cost
`sorted(xs)` / `xs.sort()`	O(n log n), O(n) if already sorted, **stable**	`a[i:j]` slice	O(j − i) — copies
`len(x)` (built-ins)	O(1)	`"".join(parts)`	O(total length)
`s1 | s2`	O(len s1 + len s2)	`s1 & s2`	O(min(len s1, len s2))
`min` / `max` / `sum`	O(n)	`Counter(xs)`	O(n)
`heapq.nlargest(k, xs)`	O(n log k)	`list(dict)`	O(n)

Big-O: O(1) constant, O(log n) halving, O(n) linear, O(n log n) good sorting, O(n²) nested loops; "avg" = typical, a rare worst case can be slower (glossary: *Big-O*, *Amortised O(1)*).

Rules: membership tests in a loop → use a `set`; queues → `deque`; repeated "smallest next" → `heapq`; never build strings with `+=` in a loop → `"".join` (§4.8, §17.5).

21.4 String methods and formatting (Ch 4)

Strings are **immutable**: every method returns a new string (§4.2). Index from 0; negative indexes count from the end; slices `s[start:stop:step]` exclude `stop` and never raise (§4.4).

Group	Methods (result for `s = " Hello, World "` where shown)
Case	`lower()`, `upper()`, `title()`, `capitalize()`, `swapcase()`, `casefold()` (aggressive lower for comparisons)
Strip	`strip()` → `'Hello, World'`, `lstrip()`, `rstrip()`, `strip("xy")` removes those *characters*; `removeprefix("ab")`, `removesuffix(".py")` remove an exact prefix/suffix (3.9+)
Split / join	`split()` (any whitespace), `split(",")`, `split(",", 1)`, `rsplit`, `splitlines()`, `partition(":")` → 3-tuple; `", ".join(items)`
Search	`x in s` (preferred test), `find(sub)` → index or **`-1`**, `index(sub)` → index or **`ValueError`**, `rfind`, `count(sub)`, `startswith(("a", "b"))`, `endswith`
Replace	`replace(old, new, count)`, `translate(str.maketrans("abc", "xyz"))`, `expandtabs()`
Checks	`isdigit()`, `isdecimal()`, `isnumeric()`, `isalpha()`, `isalnum()`, `isspace()`, `isupper()`, `islower()`, `isidentifier()`
Align	`center(20, "*")`, `ljust(10)`, `rjust(10)`, `zfill(5)` (`"42".zfill(5)` → `'00042'`)
Encode	`s.encode("utf-8")` → `bytes`; `b.decode("utf-8")` → `str` (§4.9)

Escapes: `\n \t \\ \' \" \xhh \uXXXX \N{name}`; raw strings `r"C:\path\n"` keep backslashes (use for regex) (§4.5).

f-string format spec — `{value:[[fill]align][sign][#][0][width][,][.precision][type]}` (§4.6):

Spec	Result	Spec	Result
`f"{3.14159:.2f}"`	`3.14`	`f"{1234567:,}"`	`1,234,567`
`f"{0.256:.1%}"`	`25.6%`	`f"{42:05d}"`	`00042`
`f"{'hi':>6}"`	`hi`	`f"{'hi':*^6}"`	`**hi**`
`f"{255:#x}"` / `f"{255:b}"`	`0xff` / `11111111`	`f"{1234.5:e}"`	`1.234500e+03`
`f"{x=}"` (3.8+)	`x=…`	`f"{obj!r}"`	uses `repr()`

Other formatting: `"{} {}".format(a, b)` for stored templates, `"%s" % x` in `logging` calls, `string.Template` for user-supplied templates, t-strings `t"…"` (3.14) produce a `Template` object for safe processing (§4.6).

Regex (§4.10, §14.3): `re.search` (anywhere), `re.match` (at start), `re.fullmatch` (whole string), `re.findall`, `re.finditer`, `re.sub(pattern, repl, s)`, `re.split`, `re.compile`; groups `(...)`, named `(?P<name>...)`; always raw strings; beware catastrophic backtracking on nested quantifiers.

21.5 List, tuple, dict and set methods (Ch 5, 6)

List (§5.4, §5.5):

Method	Does	Returns
`append(x)`	add one item at the end	`None`
`extend(iterable)`	add each item	`None`
`insert(i, x)`	insert before index i	`None`
`remove(x)`	delete first `x` (`ValueError` if absent)	`None`
`pop(i=-1)`	remove and return item i	the item
`clear()`	empty the list	`None`
`index(x[, start[, end]])`	first position (`ValueError` if absent)	int
`count(x)`	occurrences	int
`sort(key=None, reverse=False)`	sort in place (stable)	`None`
`reverse()`	reverse in place	`None`
`copy()`	shallow copy (= `a[:]`)	new list

Slicing: `a[1:3]`, `a[::-1]`, `a[::2]`; slice assignment `a[1:3] = [9, 9, 9]` can resize; `del a[::2]`. Copies: `=` aliases, `a.copy()` / `a[:]` / `list(a)` shallow, `copy.deepcopy(a)` deep; grids with `[[0] * n for _ in range(m)]`, never `[[0] * n] * m` (§5.8).

Tuple (§5.9–5.13): `count(x)`, `index(x)`; packing `t = 1, 2`; unpacking `a, *rest = t`; `namedtuple("P", "x y")` / `typing.NamedTuple` for named fields (`_asdict()`, `_replace()`).

Dict (§6.1, §6.4):

Method	Does
`d[k]` / `d[k] = v` / `del d[k]`	read (`KeyError` if missing) / insert-or-update / delete
`get(k, default=None)`	read without error
`setdefault(k, default)`	return `d[k]`, inserting `default` first if missing
`update(other)` / `d |= other` / `d1 | d2`	merge (right side wins); `|` returns a new dict (3.9+)
`pop(k[, default])`	remove and return
`popitem()`	remove and return the **last** inserted pair
`keys()`, `values()`, `items()`	live **views**; `keys()`/`items()` support set operations
`dict.fromkeys(keys, value)`	new dict — the *same* `value` object for every key
`copy()`, `clear()`	shallow copy, empty

Iterating a dict yields keys, in insertion order (guaranteed since 3.7). Don't add/remove keys while iterating — loop over `list(d)`.

Set (§6.6–6.8):

Operator	Method	Meaning
`a | b`	`union`	in either
`a & b`	`intersection`	in both
`a - b`	`difference`	in a, not b
`a ^ b`	`symmetric_difference`	in exactly one
`a <= b`, `a < b`	`issubset`	subset, proper subset
`a >= b`	`issuperset`	superset
—	`isdisjoint(b)`	no common items

Mutators: `add(x)`, `update(it)`, `remove(x)` (raises if absent), `discard(x)` (doesn't), `pop()` (arbitrary item), `clear()`, and in-place `|=`, `&=`, `-=`, `^=`. Methods accept any iterable; operators need sets. `frozenset` is the immutable, hashable version.

21.6 Comprehensions, iterators and generators (§5.6, §6.5, Ch 11)

```
[x * x for x in xs]                       # list
[x for x in xs if x > 0]                  # filter: `if` at the END
["pos" if x > 0 else "neg" for x in xs]   # choose: if-else BEFORE `for`
[y for row in grid for y in row]          # nested: same order as the loops
{k: v for k, v in pairs}                  # dict
{w.lower() for w in words}                # set
(x * x for x in xs)                       # generator expression — lazy
sum(x * x for x in xs)                    # parentheses can be dropped as sole argument
```

Concept	Rule
Iterable	has `__iter__` → returns an iterator (list, str, dict, file, range) (§11.1)
Iterator	has `__next__` (raises `StopIteration` at the end) and `__iter__` returning itself; **single-pass**
`for` loop	`it = iter(x)` then `next(it)` until `StopIteration`
Generator function	contains `yield`; calling it returns a generator (an iterator) without running the body (§11.2)
`yield from sub`	delegate to a sub-iterator (§11.3)
`send`, `throw`, `close`	two-way generators (§11.3)
Lazy vs eager	generators/`map`/`filter`/`zip`/`range` produce on demand → constant memory, early exit (§11.4)
Built-in consumers	`list`, `tuple`, `set`, `dict`, `sum`, `min`, `max`, `any`, `all`, `sorted`, `"".join`, `next(it, default)`

```
def read_records(path):          # a pipeline stage: constant memory
    with open(path, encoding="utf-8") as f:
        for line in f:
            if line.strip():
                yield line.rstrip("\n").split(",")
```

21.7 Functions and arguments (Ch 7)

```
def f(pos_only, /, normal, *args, kw_only, **kwargs) -> None:
    """Docstring."""
```

Part	Meaning
before `/`	positional-only (§7.2)
normal	positional or keyword
`*args`	extra positionals → **tuple**
after `*` or `*args`	keyword-only
`**kwargs`	extra keywords → **dict**
defaults `x=1`	evaluated **once** at `def` time → use `None` for mutable defaults
call-site unpacking	`f(*seq, **mapping)`
return several	`return a, b` returns a tuple; no `return` → `None`

Topic	One-liner
Scope	**LEGB**: Local → Enclosing → Global → Built-in; assignment makes a name local for the whole function; `global x`, `nonlocal x` to rebind outer names (§7.3)
Closure	inner function remembering outer variables; binds **late** (§7.4)
First-class	functions are objects: pass, return, store; `key=` functions (§7.5)
`lambda`	`lambda x: x * 2` — one expression; don't assign to a name
`map` / `filter`	lazy iterators; comprehensions usually clearer (§7.5, §11.7)
Decorator	`@d` over `def f` ≡ `f = d(f)`; use `functools.wraps` (§7.6, §12.1)
Recursion	base case + progress; limit ~1000 frames (`sys.getrecursionlimit()`); no tail-call optimisation (§7.7)
Memoisation	`@functools.cache` / `@lru_cache(maxsize=128)`; arguments must be hashable (§7.6)
Docs and hints	docstring → `help(f)`; annotations are not enforced (§7.8)

21.8 OOP and dunder methods (Ch 10, §12.4–12.6)

```python
from dataclasses import dataclass, field

class Account:
    bank = "PyBank"                       # class attribute (shared)
    def __init__(self, owner: str, balance: float = 0):
        self.owner = owner                # instance attribute
        self._balance = balance           # _ = internal by convention
    @property
    def balance(self) -> float:           # computed/validated attribute
        return self._balance
    @classmethod
    def empty(cls, owner):                # alternative constructor
        return cls(owner)
    @staticmethod
    def valid_amount(x) -> bool:          # helper, no self/cls
        return x > 0
    def __repr__(self):
        return f"Account({self.owner!r}, {self._balance})"

@dataclass(frozen=True, slots=True)
class Point:
    x: float
    y: float = 0.0
    tags: tuple[str, ...] = ()            # mutable defaults need field(default_factory=list)
```

Syntax / built-in	Dunder	Syntax / built-in	Dunder
`Cls(...)` create / init	`__new__` / `__init__`	`repr(x)` / `str(x)`	`__repr__` / `__str__`
`x == y`, `x < y`	`__eq__`, `__lt__` …	`hash(x)`	`__hash__`
`x + y`, `y + x` fallback, `x += y`	`__add__`, `__radd__`, `__iadd__`	`bool(x)`	`__bool__` (else `__len__`)
`len(x)`	`__len__`	`x[k]`, `x[k] = v`, `del x[k]`	`__getitem__`, `__setitem__`, `__delitem__`
`for a in x`	`__iter__` / `__next__`	`a in x`	`__contains__`
`x(...)`	`__call__`	`with x:`	`__enter__` / `__exit__`
`x.attr` missing	`__getattr__`	every `x.attr`	`__getattribute__`
descriptor protocol	`__get__`, `__set__`, `__delete__`	subclass hook	`__init_subclass__`
`f"{x:spec}"`	`__format__`	pattern matching positions	`__match_args__`

Rule	Section
Always write `__repr__`; `__str__` falls back to it	§10.2
Defining `__eq__` without `__hash__` makes instances unhashable	§10.2
Return `NotImplemented` (not `False`) for unsupported operand types	§10.3
`super()` = next class in the instance's **MRO** (C3 linearisation); `Cls.__mro__`	§10.4, §10.5
Mixins add small capabilities via multiple inheritance	§10.6
Duck typing by default; ABCs enforce methods at instantiation; `Protocol` for structural static typing	§10.7
Prefer composition (has-a) unless it's a genuine is-a	§10.8
`_x` internal by convention; `__x` is name-mangled to `_Cls__x`, not private	§10.9
`@dataclass` options: `frozen`, `order`, `slots`, `kw_only`, `field(default_factory=…)`	§10.10
`enum.Enum`, `IntEnum`, `StrEnum`, `Flag`, `auto()`	§10.11
`__slots__` removes the per-instance `__dict__` → less memory, no new attributes	§10.12
`functools.total_ordering` fills in comparisons from `__eq__` + one of `__lt__` …	§10.2, §12.2

21.9 Exceptions (Ch 9)

```
try:
    value = int(text)
except ValueError as e:               # specific first; the first matching except wins
    log.warning("bad input %r: %s", text, e)
    value = 0
except (TypeError, KeyError):
    raise                             # re-raise unchanged
else:
    print("parsed OK")                # only if no exception
finally:
    cleanup()                         # always

class AppError(Exception): ...        # custom hierarchy
class NotFound(AppError): ...
raise NotFound("user 42") from err    # chain: keeps the cause (__cause__)
e.add_note("while loading config")    # 3.11+
```

Hierarchy (partial)	Raised when
`BaseException` → `SystemExit`, `KeyboardInterrupt`, `GeneratorExit`, `Exception`	root; don't catch it
`Exception` → `ArithmeticError` → `ZeroDivisionError`, `OverflowError`	maths
`LookupError` → `IndexError`, `KeyError`	bad index / missing key
`ValueError` (→ `UnicodeError`)	right type, bad value
`TypeError`	wrong type
`AttributeError`, `NameError` (→ `UnboundLocalError`)	missing attribute / name
`OSError` → `FileNotFoundError`, `PermissionError`, `TimeoutError`, `ConnectionError`	OS / I/O
`ImportError` → `ModuleNotFoundError`	import failed
`RuntimeError` → `RecursionError`, `NotImplementedError`	generic runtime problems
`StopIteration`	iterator exhausted
`ExceptionGroup` + `except*` (3.11+)	several errors at once, e.g. from `asyncio.TaskGroup` (§9.6)

Rules: keep `try` blocks small; never bare `except:` (catches Ctrl+C); prefer EAFP (§9.5); `assert` is for internal invariants only — it is removed by `python -O` (§9.7); read tracebacks bottom-up (§9.1, §15.10).

21.10 Files, paths and data formats (§9.8–9.11, §14.6)

```
from pathlib import Path
p = Path("data") / "sales.csv"
p.parent.mkdir(parents=True, exist_ok=True)
text = p.read_text(encoding="utf-8");  p.write_text("a,b\n", encoding="utf-8")
with p.open(encoding="utf-8") as f:       # stream big files line by line
    for line in f: ...
with open("img.png", "rb") as f: data = f.read()        # binary: bytes, no encoding
for q in Path(".").rglob("*.py"): print(q.name, q.stem, q.suffix)
```

Mode	Meaning	Mode	Meaning
`"r"`	read text (default)	`"rb"` / `"wb"`	binary read / write
`"w"`	write, **truncates**	`"a"`	append
`"x"`	create, fail if it exists	`"r+"`	read and write

Task	Tool
Paths, globbing, read/write small files	`pathlib.Path` (§9.10)
Copy/move/delete trees, archives	`shutil.copytree`, `shutil.move`, `shutil.rmtree`, `shutil.make_archive`
Scratch files/dirs	`tempfile.TemporaryDirectory()`, `NamedTemporaryFile`
Atomic write	write to a temp file in the same folder, then `os.replace(tmp, final)`
CSV	`csv.reader/writer`, `csv.DictReader/DictWriter`; open with `newline=""`; values come back as `str` (§9.11)
JSON	`json.load/dump` (files), `json.loads/dumps` (strings), `indent=2`, `default=str` for unknown types
Python objects	`pickle` — Python-only, **never load untrusted data**
Tabular analytics	pandas `read_csv` / `read_parquet` (§18.4)
Embedded SQL	`sqlite3` with `?` placeholders (§14.11)

Always pass `encoding="utf-8"` for text files (§9.9).

21.11 `itertools`, `functools`, `collections` (§6.9, §7.6, §11.5, §12.2)

`itertools` (all lazy) — results for small inputs:

Function	Example → result
`count(start, step)`	`count(10, 5)` → 10, 15, 20, … (infinite)
`cycle(it)` / `repeat(x, n)`	`cycle("ab")` → a, b, a, …; `repeat(0, 3)` → 0, 0, 0
`chain(a, b)` / `chain.from_iterable(xss)`	`chain([1, 2], [3])` → 1, 2, 3
`islice(it, stop)` / `islice(it, start, stop, step)`	`islice(count(), 3)` → 0, 1, 2
`takewhile` / `dropwhile`	`takewhile(lambda x: x < 3, [1, 2, 5, 1])` → 1, 2
`groupby(it, key)`	groups **consecutive** equal keys — sort first
`accumulate(it[, func])`	`accumulate([1, 2, 3])` → 1, 3, 6
`pairwise(it)` (3.10+)	`pairwise("abc")` → ('a','b'), ('b','c')
`batched(it, n)` (3.12+)	`batched("abcde", 2)` → ('a','b'), ('c','d'), ('e',)
`zip_longest(a, b, fillvalue=None)`	pads the shorter input
`product(a, b)` / `product(a, repeat=2)`	Cartesian product
`permutations(it, r)`	`permutations("abc", 2)` → 6 ordered pairs
`combinations(it, r)`	`combinations("abc", 2)` → ab, ac, bc
`combinations_with_replacement`	allows repeats
`starmap(f, pairs)`	`f(*pair)` for each
`tee(it, n)`	n independent iterators from one

`functools`:

Tool	Use
`@cache` / `@lru_cache(maxsize=…)`	memoise pure functions; `.cache_info()`, `.cache_clear()`
`@cached_property`	compute an attribute once per instance
`@wraps(func)`	keep name/docstring in decorators
`partial(f, *args, **kw)`	pre-fill arguments
`reduce(f, it, initial)`	fold to one value (prefer `sum`, `max`, `math.prod` when they fit)
`@total_ordering`	derive comparison methods
`cmp_to_key(cmp)`	use an old-style comparator as `key=`
`@singledispatch`	overload a function by the first argument's type

collections:

Type	One-liner
`Counter(it)`	counts; `most_common(k)`; missing key → 0; `+ - & |`
`defaultdict(list)`	auto-creates missing values (a *read* inserts)
`deque(maxlen=n)`	O(1) at both ends; `rotate`; bounded buffer
`namedtuple("P", "x y")`	tuple with field names
`OrderedDict`	`move_to_end`, `popitem(last=False)`; order-sensitive `==`
`ChainMap(a, b)`	look up keys in several mappings in order

21.12 Decorators, context managers, metaprogramming (Ch 12)

```python
import functools, time
from contextlib import contextmanager

def timed(func):                                    # plain decorator
    @functools.wraps(func)
    def wrapper(*args, **kwargs):
        t0 = time.perf_counter()
        try:
            return func(*args, **kwargs)
        finally:
            print(f"{func.__name__}: {time.perf_counter() - t0:.3f}s")
    return wrapper

def retry(times):                                   # decorator factory (3 levels)
    def decorator(func):
        @functools.wraps(func)
        def wrapper(*args, **kwargs):
            for attempt in range(times):
                try:
                    return func(*args, **kwargs)
                except OSError:
                    if attempt == times - 1:
                        raise
        return wrapper
    return decorator

@contextmanager
def opened(path):                                   # generator-based context manager
    f = open(path, encoding="utf-8")
    try:
        yield f                                     # value bound by `as`
    finally:
        f.close()                                   # always runs
```

Fact	Section
Stacked decorators are applied bottom-up, and the wrappers run top-down	§12.1
Decorators run at **definition** time; wrappers run at **call** time	§12.1
`__exit__` returning a truthy value suppresses the exception	§12.3
`contextlib`: `suppress`, `closing`, `nullcontext`, `redirect_stdout`, `chdir` (3.11+), `ExitStack` (dynamic number of managers, closes LIFO)	§12.3
Async versions: `async with`, `@asynccontextmanager`	§12.3
Descriptors (`__get__`/`__set__`) power `property`, methods, `classmethod`, `staticmethod`; data descriptors beat the instance `__dict__`	§12.4
`__getattr__` runs only when normal lookup fails; `__getattribute__` runs for every access	§12.5
Metaclass = class of a class (`type` by default); prefer class decorators or `__init_subclass__`	§12.6
Monkey patching: fine in tests with automatic restore (`mock.patch`, `monkeypatch`); avoid in production	§12.7
Introspection: `type`, `isinstance`, `dir`, `vars`, `getattr`/`setattr`/`hasattr`, `inspect`; never `eval`/`exec` untrusted input	§12.8

21.13 Type hints (Ch 13)

```python
from typing import Protocol, TypedDict, Literal, Final, NewType, Callable, Any

def greet(name: str, times: int = 1) -> str: ...
scores: dict[str, list[float]] = {}
maybe: int | None = None                        # = Optional[int]
def first[T](xs: list[T]) -> T: ...             # 3.12 generic syntax
type Matrix = list[list[float]]                 # 3.12 type alias statement
Handler = Callable[[str, int], bool]
Mode = Literal["r", "w"]
MAX: Final = 100
UserId = NewType("UserId", int)

class SupportsClose(Protocol):                  # structural: no inheritance needed
    def close(self) -> None: ...

class Movie(TypedDict):
    title: str
    year: int
```

Concept	Meaning	Section
Not enforced	the interpreter ignores hints; mypy/pyright check them statically	§13.1
Gradual typing	add hints where they pay off; unannotated code is `Any`	§13.1
Accept abstract, return concrete	parameters `Iterable` / `Sequence` / `Mapping` (from `collections.abc`), return `list` / `dict`	§13.3
Invariance	`list[bool]` is not a `list[int]`; `Sequence` is covariant	§13.3
Narrowing	`if x is not None:` / `isinstance` refine a union	§13.4
`Any` vs `object`	`Any` switches checking off; `object` allows only what every object supports	§13.5
`TypeVar` / bounds / constraints	generic functions and classes	§13.6
`ParamSpec`	type decorators that preserve signatures	§13.7
`Protocol`, `TypedDict`, `Literal`, `Final`, `NewType`	structural interface, typed dict shape, fixed values, constant, distinct zero-cost type	§13.8–13.10
Tools	`mypy --strict`, `pyright`, `reveal_type(x)`, `# type: ignore[code]`, stub packages `types-*`	§13.13
Runtime validation	pydantic / FastAPI at the boundary	§13.14

21.14 Standard-library quick picks (Ch 14)

Need	Module / call	Section
Dates and times	`datetime.now(UTC)`, `ZoneInfo("Europe/Paris")`, `isoformat()`, `fromisoformat()`, `timedelta` — store aware UTC	§14.1
Durations / timeouts	`time.perf_counter()` / `time.monotonic()`; `time.time()` = epoch seconds	§14.2
Regex	`re` (see 21.4)	§14.3
Logging	`log = logging.getLogger(__name__)`; configure once (`basicConfig` / `dictConfig`); `log.info("x=%s", x)`; `log.exception(...)` in `except`	§14.4
CLI arguments	`argparse.ArgumentParser`, `add_argument`, subcommands	§14.5
Environment, argv, exit	`os.environ.get("KEY", default)`, `sys.argv`, `sys.exit(code)`	§14.6
Run commands	`subprocess.run(["git", "status"], check=True, capture_output=True, text=True, timeout=30)` — a list, not a shell string	§14.6
Random	`random.Random(42)` for reproducible simulations; `secrets.token_urlsafe()` for tokens/passwords	§14.7
Maths / stats	`math.isclose`, `math.gcd`, `math.isqrt`, `math.comb`; `statistics.mean/median/stdev/quantiles`	§14.8
Exact numbers	`decimal.Decimal("0.10")`, `fractions.Fraction(1, 3)`	§14.8
Copy / pretty print	`copy.deepcopy`, `pprint.pp`	§14.9
IDs / hashes	`uuid.uuid4()`; `hashlib.sha256(b).hexdigest()` (use a KDF such as `hashlib.scrypt` for passwords)	§14.9
Embedded DB	`sqlite3.connect`, `with con:` transactions, `?` placeholders	§14.11
URLs / HTTP	`urllib.parse`; `urllib.request` for quick scripts; `requests` / `httpx` for real work	§14.12

21.15 Modules, packages and environments (Ch 8)

Task	Command / rule	Section
Import styles	`import json`, `from pathlib import Path`, `import numpy as np`; avoid `import *`	§8.1
How import works	check `sys.modules` → search `sys.path` → create module, register it, run it once → bind the name	§8.2
Package	folder with `__init__.py` (regular) or without (namespace); `__all__` controls `import *`	§8.3
Relative import	`from .utils import x` — only inside packages; run with `python -m pkg.mod`	§8.4
Script vs module	`if __name__ == "__main__":`	§8.5
Circular import fix	restructure; `import module` instead of `from module import name`; import inside the function	§8.6
Virtual env	`python -m venv .venv` → `source .venv/bin/activate` (Windows: `.venv\Scripts\activate`) → `python -m pip install pkg`	§8.7
Freeze / reproduce	`pip freeze > requirements.txt`, `pip install -r requirements.txt`	§8.8
Modern projects	`pyproject.toml` (metadata, dependencies, tool config) + lock file; `uv add pkg`, `uv run`, `uv sync`; Poetry similar	§8.8
Layout and publishing	`src/` layout; build sdist + wheel (`python -m build` / `uv build`); TestPyPI → PyPI (Trusted Publishing)	§8.9

21.16 Testing and debugging (Ch 15)

```python
# test_prices.py — run with: pytest -q
import pytest
from prices import apply_discount

@pytest.fixture
def cart():
    return {"apple": 1.0, "pear": 2.0}

@pytest.mark.parametrize("pct, expected", [(0, 3.0), (50, 1.5)])
def test_discount(cart, pct, expected):
    assert apply_discount(cart, pct) == pytest.approx(expected)

def test_rejects_negative(cart):
    with pytest.raises(ValueError, match="negative"):
        apply_discount(cart, -5)
```

Tool / idea	Key facts	Section
Test types	unit (one piece, fast), integration (pieces together), end-to-end (whole system); Arrange–Act–Assert	§15.1
`unittest`	`class T(unittest.TestCase)`, `setUp`, `assertEqual`, `assertRaises`; `python -m unittest`	§15.3
pytest	plain `assert`; fixtures (`yield` for teardown, `scope=`), `conftest.py`, `parametrize`, `tmp_path`, `monkeypatch`, `capsys`, `caplog`; marks `skip` / `skipif` / `xfail`	§15.4
pytest CLI	`-q`, `-x` (stop at first failure), `-k expr`, `-m mark`, `--lf` (last failed), `--pdb`	§15.4
Test doubles	dummy, stub, spy, mock, fake; `Mock(return_value=…, side_effect=…)`, `assert_called_once_with`; `patch("where.it.is.used")`; `autospec=True`	§15.5
Coverage	`pytest --cov=pkg --cov-branch --cov-report=term-missing`; coverage ≠ correctness	§15.6
doctest	examples in docstrings run as tests	§15.7
TDD	red → green → refactor	§15.8
Hypothesis	property-based tests: `@given(st.lists(st.integers()))`; shrinks failures	§15.9
Tracebacks	read the last line first, then walk up the frames	§15.10
Debugger	`breakpoint()` → pdb: `n` next, `s` step, `c` continue, `p expr`, `w` where, `u` / `d` up/down, `b` breakpoint, `q` quit	§15.11
Logging vs print	logging for anything that stays in the code	§15.12

21.17 Concurrency: which tool? (Ch 16)

Situation	Use	Why
Tens–hundreds of blocking I/O calls (HTTP, DB, files), sync libraries	`ThreadPoolExecutor` / `threading`	GIL is released while waiting
Thousands of concurrent connections, async libraries	`asyncio`	one thread, cheap tasks
CPU-bound pure Python	`ProcessPoolExecutor` / `multiprocessing`	one GIL per process → real parallelism
CPU-bound numeric work	numpy/pandas vectorisation	C loops
CPU-bound threads with shared memory, compatible deps	free-threaded build (`python3.14t`)	no GIL (optional build)
Pipeline stages	threads/processes + `queue.Queue` (bounded)	backpressure, sentinels for shutdown
Blocking call inside async code	`await asyncio.to_thread(func, ...)`	keeps the event loop responsive
Beyond one machine	Celery, RQ, Dask, Ray, Spark	distributed

	Threads	Processes	asyncio
Parallel CPU (standard build)	no	yes	no
Shared memory	yes (needs locks)	no (pickled messages)	yes (one thread)
Switching	pre-emptive	OS	cooperative at `await`
Cost per unit	~MB stack	whole interpreter	~KB

```python
from concurrent.futures import ThreadPoolExecutor, as_completed
with ThreadPoolExecutor(max_workers=8) as ex:
    futures = [ex.submit(fetch, url) for url in urls]
    for fut in as_completed(futures):          # completion order; ex.map keeps input order
        print(fut.result())                    # re-raises the worker's exception

import asyncio
async def main():
    async with asyncio.TaskGroup() as tg:       # 3.11+: structured concurrency
        tasks = [tg.create_task(fetch_async(u)) for u in urls]
    return [t.result() for t in tasks]
asyncio.run(main())
```

Synchronisation (§16.4): `Lock` (mutual exclusion; `with lock:`), `RLock` (re-entrant), `Semaphore(n)` (at most n holders), `Event`, `Condition`. Pitfalls (§16.11): races on shared state, deadlocks (take locks in a global order, use timeouts), blocking calls in coroutines, lost exceptions in fire-and-forget tasks, missing `if __name__ == "__main__":` with processes.

21.18 Performance and internals (Ch 17)

Fact	Section
Everything is an object with identity (`id`), type and value; CPython objects carry a reference count and a type pointer	§17.1
Memory: reference counting frees objects immediately; a generational cyclic GC collects reference cycles; `weakref` refers without owning	§17.2
Small ints −5…256 and some strings are cached/interned → never compare values with `is`	§17.3
Assignment shares; `.copy()` is shallow; `deepcopy` is deep	§17.4

Measure first (§17.6):

Question	Tool
How fast is this snippet?	`python -m timeit "..."`, `timeit.timeit(fn, number=…)`, `%timeit` in Jupyter
Which functions are slow?	`python -m cProfile -s cumtime script.py`, `pstats` (ncalls, tottime, cumtime)
Which lines?	`line_profiler` (`kernprof -l -v`)
Live / low-overhead	`py-spy top --pid N`, `scalene`, `pyinstrument`
Which lines allocate memory?	`tracemalloc` snapshots

Optimise in this order (§17.7): better algorithm/data structure (set for membership, dict for lookup, deque for queues) → cache repeated work (`functools.cache`) → vectorise with numpy/pandas → stream with generators → built-ins, comprehensions, `str.join`, local variables in hot loops → `__slots__` for many small objects → compile hot spots (numba, Cython, Rust/PyO3, mypyc) or use PyPy → parallelise (processes). Newer CPython releases (3.11+) are faster for free.

21.19 numpy, pandas, matplotlib essentials (Ch 18)

numpy (§18.1–18.3):

```
import numpy as np
a = np.array([[1, 2, 3], [4, 5, 6]])       # shape (2, 3), dtype int64
a.shape, a.ndim, a.dtype, a.size
np.zeros((2, 3)); np.ones(3); np.arange(0, 10, 2); np.linspace(0, 1, 5); np.eye(3)
a[0, 1]; a[:, 1]; a[a > 2]                  # index, column slice (view), boolean mask (copy)
a.sum(axis=0)                               # per column -> [5, 7, 9]
a.mean(axis=1)                              # per row    -> [2., 5.]
a * 10; a + np.array([10, 20, 30])          # vectorised + broadcasting
a @ a.T                                     # matrix product
a.reshape(3, 2); a.T; np.concatenate([a, a]); np.vstack; np.hstack
rng = np.random.default_rng(42); rng.normal(size=3); rng.integers(0, 10, 5)
np.linalg.solve(A, b); np.linalg.eigh(S)
```

Rules: slices are **views** (changing them changes the original; `.copy()` to detach); masks and fancy indexing return copies; broadcasting compares shapes from the right — dimensions must be equal or one of them 1; `axis=0` collapses rows (result per column), `axis=1` collapses columns (result per row); vectorise instead of Python loops.

pandas (§18.4–18.11, pandas 3.x):

Task	Code
Load / save	`pd.read_csv(path, parse_dates=["date"])`, `pd.read_parquet`, `df.to_parquet`
First look	`df.head()`, `df.info()`, `df.describe()`, `df["col"].value_counts()`, `df.isna().sum()`
Select	`df["col"]`, `df[["a", "b"]]`, `df.loc[row_labels, cols]` (labels, end **inclusive**), `df.iloc[0:5, 1]` (positions, end exclusive)
Filter	`df[(df.qty > 5) & (df.city == "Oslo")]` (use `&`, `|`, `~` with parentheses), `df.query("qty > 5")`
New columns	`df["rev"] = df.qty * df.price`, `df.assign(rev=lambda d: d.qty * d.price)`, `np.where`, `np.select`, `pd.cut`
Missing data	`isna`, `dropna`, `fillna`, `pd.to_numeric(errors="coerce")`
Group	`df.groupby("city")["rev"].agg(["sum", "mean"])`, named aggregation `agg(total=("rev", "sum"))`, `transform` keeps the original shape
Combine	`pd.merge(a, b, on="id", how="left", validate="m:1", indicator=True)`, `pd.concat([a, b])`
Reshape	`pivot_table(index=, columns=, values=, aggfunc=)`, `melt` (wide → long)
Dates	`pd.to_datetime(col, format=...)`, `.dt.month`, `set_index("date").resample("ME").sum()` (`"ME"` month end in pandas ≥ 2.2/3.0), `rolling(7).mean()`
Sort / top-N	`sort_values("rev", ascending=False)`, `nlargest(3, "rev")`
Speed / memory	vectorise instead of `apply`; `astype("category")` for repeated strings; Parquet over CSV

pandas 3.0 notes (§18.4–18.5): text columns use a dedicated `str` dtype; **Copy-on-Write** is always on → assign with a single `df.loc[mask, "col"] = value`, never chained indexing.

matplotlib (§18.12):

```
import matplotlib
matplotlib.use("Agg")                       # headless scripts
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(6, 4))      # object-oriented API
ax.plot(x, y, label="sales"); ax.bar(cats, vals); ax.scatter(x, y); ax.hist(data, bins=20)
ax.set(title="Sales", xlabel="Month", ylabel="EUR"); ax.legend()
fig.tight_layout(); fig.savefig("img/sales.png", dpi=120); plt.close(fig)
```

21.20 Interview patterns and gotchas (Ch 19, 20)

Pattern → Python tool (Ch 19):

Signal in the problem	Pattern	Python
sorted array, pair/triple sums	two pointers	indices `lo`, `hi` (§19.2)
contiguous subarray/substring	sliding window / prefix sums	`dict` of last seen, `accumulate`, `defaultdict(int)` (§19.2)
"seen before?", counts, groups	hashing	`set`, `Counter`, `defaultdict(list)` (§19.3)
matching brackets, "next greater"	stack / monotonic stack	`list.append/pop` (§19.4)
FIFO, level order, window max	queue / monotonic deque	`collections.deque` (§19.4)
k largest / smallest, merge k, running median	heap / two heaps	`heapq` (negate for max-heap) (§19.5)
sorted search, minimum feasible value, weighted random pick	binary search	`bisect_left/right`, `lo < hi` template, prefix sums (§19.6)
linked list, tree, serialize a tree	node classes, DFS/BFS	`@dataclass` nodes, pre-order with `#` markers (§19.7)
shortest path unweighted / weighted / dependencies	BFS / Dijkstra / topological sort	`deque`, `heapq`, in-degree counts (§19.8)
dynamic connectivity, cycles, MST	union-find	`parent` list + path compression (§19.9)
optimal value with overlapping subproblems	DP	`@cache` or a table (§19.10)
all combinations / permutations / placements	backtracking	choose → recurse → undo; `path[:]` (§19.11)
bits, parity, powers	bit tricks, number theory	`x & (x-1)`, `pow(b, e, m)`, `math.gcd`, `math.isqrt` (§19.12)
prefix lookups, autocomplete, wildcard, words on a grid	trie	`dict` of children + end-of-word field (§19.13)
locally best choice is provably safe	greedy	one pass after `sorted(key=...)`; justify by exchange argument (§19.14)
merge / insert / overlap ranges, rooms needed	intervals	sort by start (merge) or end (keep most); `heapq` of ends; sweep line (§19.15)
cycle entry, middle, O(1)-space list checks	fast & slow pointers	`slow`, `fast`, compare with `is` (§19.16)
k-th element, three values, sort a linked list	quickselect / Dutch flag / merge sort	random-pivot partition; `low` / `mid` / `high` (§19.17)
spiral/rotate matrix, 32-bit limits, collinear points	math & geometry	boundaries; explicit range check; `gcd`-reduced slopes (§19.18)

Top gotchas (§19.19, §20.2): mutable default args (`None` sentinel) · late-binding closures (`lambda i=i: i`) · `is` vs `==` · int caching/interning · mutating a list/dict while iterating · shallow copies and `[[0]*n]*m` · `dict.fromkeys(k, [])` shares one list; a `defaultdict` read inserts · mutable class attributes shared by instances · circular imports · float precision (`isclose`, `Decimal("…")`) · bare `except:` · shadowing built-ins (`list = …`) · `xs.sort()` returns `None` · `//` floors toward −∞ · recursion limit ~1000.

21.21 Which tool for which job

Job	Reach for	Not	Section
Ordered collection you append to	`list`	`tuple` (immutable)	§5.2
Fixed record / multiple return values / dict key	`tuple`, `NamedTuple`, frozen `dataclass`	`list`	§5.9, §5.13, §10.10
Look up by key	`dict`	list of pairs + search	§6.1
Membership / de-duplication	`set` (`dict.fromkeys` to keep order)	`x in list` in a loop	§6.6
Counting	`Counter`	manual dict with `if k in d`	§6.9
Grouping	`defaultdict(list)`	`setdefault` everywhere	§6.9
Queue / sliding buffer	`deque` (`maxlen`)	`list.pop(0)`	§6.9
Priority queue / top-k	`heapq`	repeated `sort`	§6.10
Sorted inserts and range queries	`bisect` (or `sortedcontainers`)	re-sort after each insert	§6.11
Numeric arrays / maths	NumPy	Python loops over lists	§5.14, §18.1
Tables, group-by, joins	pandas	nested dicts	§18.4
Simple data class	`@dataclass`	hand-written `__init__` / `__repr__` / `__eq__`	§10.10
Validate untrusted input (JSON, API)	pydantic	trusting type hints	§13.14
Named constants / fixed choices	`enum.Enum` / `StrEnum`	bare strings	§10.11
Interface without inheritance	`typing.Protocol`	ABC (when you don't control the classes)	§10.7, §13.8
Reuse behaviour	composition, small mixins	deep inheritance trees	§10.6, §10.8
Cross-cutting behaviour (timing, retry, auth)	decorator	copy-pasted code	§12.1
Setup/teardown that must happen	`with` + context manager	manual `close()`	§9.8, §12.3
Huge or infinite sequences	generators, `itertools`	building full lists	§11.2, §11.5
Paths	`pathlib`	string concatenation, `os.path` sprawl	§9.10
Config / data exchange	JSON (or TOML for config)	pickle	§9.11
Persist Python objects you trust	`pickle` / `joblib`	pickle from strangers	§9.11
Small local database	`sqlite3`	ad-hoc files	§14.11
Diagnostics in running code	`logging`	`print`	§14.4, §15.12
CLI arguments	`argparse` (or click/typer)	parsing `sys.argv` by hand	§14.5
External commands	`subprocess.run([...], check=True)`	`os.system`, `shell=True` with user input	§14.6

Job	Reach for	Not	Section
Tokens / passwords	`secrets`	`random`	§14.7
Money	`Decimal("…")` or integer cents	`float`	§2.5, §14.8
Timestamps	aware `datetime` in UTC + `zoneinfo`	naive local times	§14.1
Durations	`time.perf_counter()`	`time.time()`	§14.2
Tests	pytest (+ fixtures, parametrize)	manual prints	§15.4
Replace a dependency in a test	`unittest.mock.patch` / `monkeypatch`	editing production code	§15.5
Concurrency (I/O waits, CPU-heavy work)	see the table in 21.17	—	§16.10
Find the slow part	`cProfile`, `py-spy`	guessing	§17.6
Memoise a pure function	`functools.cache`	hand-rolled global dict	§7.6
Dependencies per project	`venv` + `pyproject.toml` (+ `uv`)	global `pip install`	§8.7, §8.8
Type-check a codebase	mypy / pyright in CI	runtime `isinstance` everywhere	§13.13

21.22 Glossary (A–Z)

Each entry: **term** — plain meaning — section where it is explained. Links go to the chapter README.

Term	Meaning	Where
ABC (abstract base class) / abstract method	A class (from `abc`) whose `@abstractmethod`-marked methods a subclass must implement before it can be instantiated	10.7
Absolute import	Import by full path from the project/package root (`from pkg.sub import x`)	8.4
Accumulate	`itertools.accumulate`: running totals (or running results of any two-argument function)	11.5
Adjacency list	Graph stored as "node → list of its neighbours", usually a `dict` of lists	19.8
Agg backend	matplotlib's non-interactive renderer that only writes image files — for scripts and servers without a screen	18.12
Aliasing	Two names bound to the same object, so a change through one is seen through the other	5.8
Amortised O(1)	An operation that is occasionally expensive but constant on average over many calls (e.g. `list.append`)	5.3
Annotation / type hint	Note describing the expected type of a parameter, return value or variable, for tools and readers; stored in `__annotations__`, not enforced	13.2
`Any`	Type-hint escape hatch that disables checking for a value	13.5
API	Application programming interface: the set of functions, classes or HTTP endpoints one piece of software offers to others	1.3
`apply` (pandas)	Runs a Python function per row/column/group — flexible but slow; prefer vectorised operations	18.11
argparse	Standard-library module for command-line options, arguments and subcommands	14.5
Argument	The actual value passed at a call (vs the parameter name in the definition)	7.1
`*args`	Parameter collecting extra positional arguments into a tuple	7.2
Arrange–Act–Assert	Test structure: set up, perform the action, check the result	15.1
`array.array`	Compact, typed array of C numbers from the standard library	5.1
ASCII	Old 7-bit character set (128 characters: English letters, digits, punctuation); the first 128 code points of Unicode	4.9
`assert`	Statement checking an internal invariant; removed when Python runs with `-O`	9.7
Associativity	Which side groups first when the same operator repeats: most are left-to-right, `**` is right-to-left	2.8
AST (abstract syntax tree)	Tree form of parsed source code that CPython compiles to bytecode	1.8
`async def` / `await`	`async def` defines a coroutine function; `await` pauses it until another awaitable finishes, letting the event loop run other work	16.9
asyncio	Standard library for single-threaded concurrency with an event loop and `async`/`await`	16.9
Atomic operation	Happens completely or not at all, with no half-finished state visible (e.g. `os.replace` of a file)	9.10
Attribute	A name attached to an object (`obj.name`): data or method	10.1
Augmented assignment	`x += 1` and friends; mutates in place for mutable objects that support it	2.8
Autospec	Mock option that makes a mock follow the real object's signature	15.5
Aware datetime	A `datetime` that carries a time zone (`tzinfo`); comparable across zones	14.1

Term	Meaning	Where
Axis (NumPy/pandas)	A dimension of an array: `axis=0` runs down rows (result per column), `axis=1` across columns (result per row)	18.1
Backpressure	Slowing producers when consumers can't keep up, e.g. with a bounded queue	16.5
Backtracking	Search that builds a candidate step by step and undoes steps that can't succeed	19.11
Banker's rounding	Round-half-to-even, used by `round()` (`round(2.5) == 2`)	2.5
Base class / subclass	The class another inherits from (parent, superclass) / the class that inherits (child)	10.4
`BaseException`	Root of all exceptions, including `SystemExit` and `KeyboardInterrupt`; catch `Exception` instead	9.1
BFS (breadth-first search)	Graph/tree traversal level by level with a queue; shortest paths in unweighted graphs	19.8
Big-O	Notation for how cost grows with input size, ignoring constants	17.5
Binary heap / `heapq` / min-heap	Complete binary tree stored in an array where each parent is ≤ its children, so the smallest item is at index 0; `heapq` implements it on a list (O(log n) push/pop)	6.10
Binary mode	Opening a file with `"b"` so reads/writes are raw `bytes` with no encoding or newline translation	9.9
Binary search	Finding a position in sorted data by halving the range each step, O(log n)	19.6
Binary search on the answer	Binary-searching a range of candidate answers using a yes/no "is this value feasible?" check	19.6
Binary tree	Tree in which every node has at most two children (left and right)	19.7
bisect	Standard-library binary search and sorted insertion on lists	6.11
Bit / byte	A bit is one binary digit (0 or 1); a byte is 8 bits, holding a value 0–255	4.9
Bitwise operator	`& | ^ ~ << >>`: work on the individual bits of integers	2.8
Black	Opinionated code formatter that rewrites Python files into one consistent style	1.11
Block	Group of statements under a line ending in `:`, marked by indentation	1.9
Blocking call	A call that makes the current thread wait (for I/O, a lock, `time.sleep`) until it finishes	16.9
Boolean	A true/false value; Python's `bool` type with `True` and `False`	2.6
Boolean mask	Array/Series of `True`/`False` used to select matching elements (`a[a > 2]`, `df[df.qty > 5]`)	18.1
Bound method	A function retrieved through an instance, with `self` already filled in	10.1
Branch coverage	Coverage metric that checks both outcomes of each decision were executed	15.6
`breakpoint()`	Built-in that drops into the debugger (pdb by default) at that line	15.11
Broadcasting	NumPy rule for combining arrays of different shapes by stretching size-1 dimensions	18.2
Brute force	Solving a problem by trying every possibility; a correct but usually slow first answer	19.20
BST (binary search tree)	Binary tree where every left subtree holds smaller keys and every right subtree larger ones	19.7

Term	Meaning	Where
Buffering	Collecting data in memory and reading/writing it in larger chunks; `flush()` forces buffered output out	9.8
Build backend	Tool named in `pyproject.toml` (hatchling, setuptools, …) that turns a project into an sdist and a wheel	8.8
Built-in function	Function always available without an import (`print`, `len`, `sorted`, `open`)	1.7
Bytecode	The low-level instructions CPython compiles source into and then interprets	1.8
`bytes`	Immutable sequence of raw bytes (0–255); text must be encoded to become bytes	4.9
C extension	Module written in C (or C++/Rust) and compiled, then imported like a normal Python module	17.7
`cached_property`	Decorator computing an attribute once per instance and storing it	12.4
Call site	The place in code where a function is called (as opposed to where it is defined)	7.2
Call stack	The stack of active function frames; its depth is limited for recursion	7.7
`Callable`	Type hint for function values, e.g. `Callable[[int], str]`	13.7
Callable (object)	Anything you can call with `()`: functions, classes, methods, objects with `__call__`	12.1
Callback	Function passed to other code so that code can call it later (e.g. `key=`, an event handler)	7.4
Cancellation	Asking a running asyncio task to stop: `task.cancel()` raises `CancelledError` inside it at its next `await`	16.9
Capacity	Number of slots a dynamic array has allocated, which can exceed its current length	5.3
Capture pattern	A bare name in a `case` pattern that binds the matched value	3.4
CapWords / snake_case	Naming styles: `CapWords` for classes, `snake_case` for variables and functions, `UPPER_CASE` for constants	1.11
Cartesian product	Every combination taking one item from each input (`itertools.product`)	11.5
Catastrophic backtracking	Regex with nested repetition (e.g. `(a+)+`) that takes exponential time on some inputs	4.10
Categorical (dtype)	pandas type storing repeated strings as small integer codes — saves memory	18.11
Chained comparison	`a < b < c` meaning `a < b and b < c`, evaluating `b` once	2.8
ChainMap	`collections` mapping that searches several dicts in order	6.9
CI (continuous integration)	Service that automatically runs tests, linters and type checks on every push (e.g. GitHub Actions)	15.1
Circular import	Two modules importing each other so one sees the other half-initialised	8.6
Class	Blueprint that bundles data (attributes) and behaviour (methods)	10.1
Class attribute	Attribute defined in the class body, shared by all instances	10.1
Class decorator	A decorator applied to a class instead of a function	12.1
`classmethod`	Method receiving the class (`cls`) — used for alternative constructors	10.1
CLI (command-line interface)	A program you run by typing a command and options in a terminal	14.5

Term	Meaning	Where
click / typer	Third-party libraries for building command-line interfaces with decorators or type hints	14.13
Closure	Inner function that remembers variables from its enclosing function	7.4
Code object	Compiled bytecode plus constants and names for one function/module	1.8
Code point	The number Unicode assigns to a character (`ord("A") == 65`)	4.9
Collision (hash)	Two different keys mapping to the same hash-table slot; the table must probe for another slot	6.2
Combinations / permutations	Ways to choose r items ignoring order / respecting order (`itertools.combinations`, `permutations`)	11.5
Compact dict	CPython's dict layout since 3.6: a small index table pointing into a dense, insertion-ordered entries array	6.2
Compiler	Program that translates source code into another form (bytecode or machine code) before it runs	1.8
Comprehension	Expression building a list/dict/set from an iterable: `[f(x) for x in xs if c]`	5.6
Composition	Building objects that *have* other objects instead of inheriting from them	10.8
Concat (pandas)	`pd.concat` stacks DataFrames on top of each other (or side by side) without matching keys	18.8
Concurrency	Making progress on several tasks by interleaving them (not necessarily at the same instant)	16.1
`concurrent.futures`	High-level executors (`ThreadPoolExecutor`, `ProcessPoolExecutor`) returning futures	16.8
Condition (threading)	Synchronisation object letting threads wait until another thread signals that some state has changed	16.4
Conditional expression	One-line `a if cond else b` that evaluates to one of two values	3.3
`conftest.py`	pytest file whose fixtures are shared by tests in its directory	15.4
Constructor	The call that creates an object (`Cls(...)`), running `__new__` then `__init__`	10.1
Container	Object that holds other objects (`list`, `dict`, `set`, `tuple`…); supports `in`	2.4
Context manager	Object with `__enter__`/`__exit__` used by `with` to guarantee setup and cleanup	9.8
`contextmanager`	`contextlib` decorator turning a one-`yield` generator into a context manager	12.3
Contiguous	Stored side by side in one unbroken block of memory (or a range with no gaps)	5.1
Cooperative multiple inheritance	Every class in the hierarchy calls `super()` so each `__init__`/method in the MRO runs exactly once	10.5
Cooperative multitasking	Tasks voluntarily give up control (at `await`), unlike threads, which the OS pre-empts at any moment	16.9
Copy-on-Write	pandas 3 rule: derived objects behave as copies; modify with one `.loc` assignment	18.5
Core (CPU)	One independent processing unit of a processor; several cores can run code truly in parallel	16.1

Term	Meaning	Where
Coroutine	The object returned by calling an `async def` function (a *coroutine function*); the event loop runs it, pausing at each `await`	16.9
Counter	`collections` dict subclass for counting hashable items	6.9
Covariance	A generic type that follows its element's subtyping: a `Sequence[bool]` is accepted where `Sequence[int]` is expected	13.3
Coverage	Measurement of which lines/branches the tests executed	15.6
cProfile	Built-in deterministic profiler reporting time per function	17.6
CPU time	Time the processor actually spent running your code (excludes waiting); compare with wall time	16.2
CPU-bound	Work limited by computation speed rather than waiting	16.2
CPython	The reference Python implementation, written in C	1.8
Critical section	Code touching shared state that only one thread may run at a time	16.4
Cross-cutting concern	Behaviour needed in many unrelated places (logging, timing, retries, auth) — a natural fit for decorators	12.1
CSV	Comma-separated text tables; `csv` module; all values read back as strings	9.11
Cython	Python-like language compiled to C to speed up hot code or wrap C libraries	17.7
Daemon thread	Background thread that is killed abruptly when the main program exits	16.3
DAG (directed acyclic graph)	Directed graph with no cycles — e.g. task dependencies; can be topologically sorted	19.8
Data descriptor	Descriptor defining `__set__` or `__delete__`; it takes priority over the instance `__dict__` (e.g. `property`)	12.4
Data model	Python's rules for how objects plug into syntax and built-ins via dunder methods	10.2
dataclass	`@dataclass` generates `__init__`, `__repr__`, `__eq__` from annotated fields	10.10
DataFrame	pandas 2-D labelled table of columns (each column a Series)	18.4
Deadlock	Threads waiting for each other's locks forever	16.11
Debugger	Tool that pauses a running program so you can step line by line and inspect variables (pdb, IDE debuggers)	15.11
`Decimal`	Exact decimal arithmetic type for money; construct from strings	14.8
Decorator	Callable that takes a function (or class) and returns a replacement; `@d` means `f = d(f)`	12.1
Decorator factory	Function taking arguments that returns a decorator (`@retry(times=3)`), giving three nested levels	12.1
Deep copy	Recursive copy of an object and everything it contains (`copy.deepcopy`)	5.8
`defaultdict`	Dict that creates a default value for a missing key on access	6.9
Deferred import	Import placed inside a function so it runs only when needed — breaks circular imports or speeds start-up	8.6
Dependency	External package your project needs; also any object a piece of code relies on (replaced by doubles in tests)	8.8
Dependency injection	Passing collaborators (clock, DB, HTTP client) in as arguments so tests can supply fakes	15.5

Term	Meaning	Where
deque	Double-ended queue with O(1) appends/pops at both ends	6.9
Descriptor	Object with `__get__`/`__set__`/`__delete__` that controls attribute access on a class	12.4
Deserialize / serialize	Turning stored bytes/text back into objects / turning objects into bytes or text (JSON, pickle)	9.11
DFS (depth-first search)	Traversal that goes as deep as possible before backtracking (recursion or stack)	19.8
dict	Mutable mapping from hashable keys to values; hash table, insertion-ordered	6.1
Dict view	Live, set-like object from `keys()`/`items()`/`values()`	6.4
Dijkstra's algorithm	Shortest paths with non-negative weights using a min-heap	19.8
Django / Flask / FastAPI	Popular Python web frameworks: full-featured / minimal / async and type-hint driven	1.3
Docstring	String literal as the first statement of a module/class/function, shown by `help()`	1.10
doctest	Runs examples written in docstrings as tests	15.7
DST (daylight saving time)	Seasonal clock shift that makes some local times repeat or not exist — why you store UTC	14.1
dtype	NumPy/pandas element type (`int64`, `float64`, `bool`, `category`…)	18.1
Duck typing	Using an object by what it can do, not by its class	10.7
Dummy	Test double passed only to fill a parameter, never actually used	15.5
Dummy head	Placeholder node placed before a linked list's first node so inserts/deletes at the front need no special case	19.7
Dunder method	"Double underscore" special method like `__len__` that Python calls for syntax	10.2
Dutch national flag	One-pass, three-way partition of an array into "less / equal / greater" regions using low/mid/high pointers	19.17
Dynamic array	Array that over-allocates and grows by copying — how `list` works	5.3
Dynamic programming (DP)	Solving overlapping subproblems once and combining their answers	19.10
Dynamic typing	Types belong to objects; names can be rebound to any type	2.3
EAFP	"Easier to ask forgiveness than permission": try, then handle the exception	9.5
Eager evaluation	Computing every result immediately (a list comprehension) — the opposite of lazy	11.4
Editable install	Installing a project so source edits take effect without reinstalling (`pip install -e .`)	8.8
Ellipsis (`...`)	Built-in singleton object, often used as a placeholder body in stubs; also NumPy slicing shorthand	3.8
Encoding / encode / decode	Rule turning text into bytes (UTF-8 is the standard); `str.encode()` text → bytes, `bytes.decode()` bytes → text	4.9
End-to-end (E2E) test	Test of the whole system as a user would exercise it, from input to final output	15.1
Enum	Class of named constant members (`enum.Enum`, `StrEnum`, `auto()`)	10.11
`enumerate`	Built-in yielding `(index, item)` pairs	3.6

Term	Meaning	Where
Environment variable	Named setting provided by the operating system to a process (`os.environ["HOME"]`)	14.6
Epoch	Reference time 1970-01-01 UTC that `time.time()` counts seconds from	14.2
Escape sequence	Backslash code in a string literal standing for a special character (`\n`, `\t`, `é`)	4.5
`eval` / `exec`	Built-ins that run a string as Python code — dangerous on untrusted input	12.8
Event (threading)	Flag threads can wait on until another thread sets it	16.4
Event loop	The asyncio scheduler that runs ready coroutines and waits for I/O	16.9
Exception	Object representing an error, raised to unwind the stack until handled	9.1
Exception chaining	Linking a new exception to its cause with `raise … from …`	9.4
ExceptionGroup	Exception bundling several errors, handled with `except*` (3.11+)	9.6
Exchange argument	Greedy-correctness proof: swapping any optimal solution's choice for the greedy one never makes it worse	19.14
Executor	Pool that runs callables on threads or processes and returns futures	16.8
Exit code	Integer a process returns when it ends: 0 means success, non-zero means failure (`sys.exit(code)`)	14.6
ExitStack	`contextlib` tool managing a dynamic number of context managers	12.3
Expression / statement	An expression produces a value (`x + 1`); a statement performs an action (`if`, `for`, `x = 1`)	1.9
f-string	String literal `f"…{expr:spec}…"` that evaluates and formats expressions	4.6
Fake	Test double with a working lightweight implementation (e.g. in-memory DB)	15.5
Fall-through	In other languages' `switch`, running into the next case; Python's `match` never does this	3.4
Falsy / truthy	Value treated as false in a condition (`None`, `False`, zeros, empty containers) / as true (anything else)	2.6
Fancy indexing	NumPy indexing with an array of positions (`a[[0, 2]]`); returns a copy	18.1
Fast and slow pointers	Two pointers moving at speeds 1 and 2 to find a list's middle or a cycle's entry in O(1) space (Floyd)	19.16
Figure / Axes	matplotlib's whole image / a single plot area within it	18.12
File object	Object returned by `open()` with `read`, `write`, iteration and `close`	9.8
File-like object	Any object with file methods (`read`/`write`), e.g. `io.StringIO`, usable where a file is expected	9.9
`Final`	Type hint marking a name that must not be reassigned	13.10
Finder / loader	Parts of the import system: a finder locates a module, a loader executes it to create the module object	8.2
First-class function	Functions are objects: they can be stored, passed and returned	7.5
Fixture	pytest function providing setup (and teardown) injected into tests by name	15.4
Flaky test	Test that sometimes passes and sometimes fails with no code change (timing, randomness, network)	15.5
float	IEEE-754 double-precision number; approximate for most decimals	2.5
Floor division	`//`: divide and round toward negative infinity	2.5

Term	Meaning	Where
for-else	`else` block that runs when a loop ends without `break`	3.9
Format spec	Mini-language after `:` in f-strings (`>10`, `,.2f`, `%`, `x`)	4.6
Forward reference	Type hint naming a class not yet defined, written as a string (`"Node"`) or resolved lazily	13.2
`Fraction`	Exact rational number type (`fractions.Fraction(1, 3)`)	14.8
Frame	Per-call workspace holding a function's local variables	7.1
Free variable	Variable used in a function but defined in an enclosing function — what a closure captures	7.4
Free-threaded build	Optional CPython build without the GIL (experimental in 3.13, supported in 3.14)	16.6
frozenset	Immutable, hashable set	6.8
Functional programming	Style built from pure functions, immutable data and functions passed as values (`map`, `filter`, `reduce`)	11.7
functools	Module of higher-order tools: `cache`, `lru_cache`, `partial`, `reduce`, `wraps`	7.6
Future	Placeholder for a result that will be available later (`.result()`)	16.8
Garbage collector (cyclic)	CPython component that finds and frees reference cycles	17.2
Generations (GC)	The cyclic garbage collector groups objects by age and scans young ones most often	17.2
Generator / generator object	Iterator returned by calling a function containing `yield`; its body runs only as values are requested, pausing between them	11.2
Generator expression	Lazy comprehension in parentheses: `(x * x for x in xs)`	11.2
Generic type / generic class	Type parameterised by other types (`list[int]`, `dict[str, float]`); a generic class takes a type variable (`class Box[T]`) so `Box[int]` and `Box[str]` are checked separately	13.6
GIL (Global Interpreter Lock)	CPython lock letting one thread run Python bytecode at a time	16.6
Git	Version-control system that records every change to a project's files	1.4
`global`	Statement letting a function rebind a module-level name	7.3
Gotcha	Behaviour that surprises people and causes bugs (mutable defaults, late binding, …)	20.2
GraalPy / MicroPython	Alternative Python implementations: on the Java VM / on tiny microcontrollers	1.8
Gradual typing	Adding type hints incrementally; unannotated code is treated as `Any`	13.1
Graph (nodes, edges; directed / weighted)	Set of nodes (vertices) connected by edges — maps, networks, dependencies; directed edges have a direction, weighted edges carry a cost	19.8
Greedy algorithm	Builds an answer by always taking the locally best choice; correct only when an exchange argument proves it	19.14
groupby (itertools)	Groups *consecutive* items with equal keys — sort first	11.5
groupby (pandas)	Split–apply–combine: aggregate or transform rows per group	18.7
Guard (match)	`if` condition attached to a `case` pattern	3.4
Guard clause	Early `return`/`continue` for special cases to keep code flat	3.2

Term	Meaning	Where
Has-a / is-a	Composition (a car *has an* engine) vs inheritance (a car *is a* vehicle)	10.8
Hash / hash function	Hash function: maps any data to a fixed-size value; `hash()` gives the integer that places a value in a hash table; cryptographic ones (SHA-256) are hard to reverse or collide	6.2
Hash randomisation	str/bytes hashes are salted with a random per-process seed (`PYTHONHASHSEED`), so set order can change between runs	6.2
Hash table	Array of slots indexed by hash — the structure behind dict and set	6.2
Hashable	Has a hash that never changes and consistent `__eq__`; can be a dict key or set item	6.2
hashlib	Standard-library cryptographic hash functions (SHA-256…)	14.9
Heapify	Turning a list into a heap in place in O(n) (`heapq.heapify`)	6.10
Hexadecimal / octal / binary	Base-16 (`0xff`), base-8 (`0o17`) and base-2 (`0b101`) ways of writing integers	2.5
Higher-order function	Function that takes or returns functions (`map`, `sorted(key=…)`, decorators)	7.5
HTTP	Protocol browsers and APIs use to send requests and responses over the web	14.12
httpx / requests	Third-party HTTP client libraries; `httpx` also supports async	14.12
Hypothesis	Library for property-based testing that generates and shrinks inputs	15.9
I/O	Input/output: reading or writing files, network, terminal — usually slow compared with the CPU	16.2
I/O-bound	Work that spends most of its time waiting on network, disk or other I/O	16.2
IDE	Integrated development environment (VS Code, PyCharm)	1.6
Idempotent	Doing it twice has the same effect as doing it once: `f(f(x)) == f(x)`	15.9
Identifier	A name for a variable, function, class, etc.	1.9
Identity	Which object a name refers to; compared with `is`, shown by `id()`	2.2
Idiom	The usual, natural way to express something in a language	20.1
IEEE-754	Standard for floating-point numbers; Python's `float` is its 64-bit "double"	2.5
`iloc` / `loc`	pandas selection by integer position / by label (label slices include the end)	18.5
Immortal object	Object (like `None` or small ints) whose refcount never changes, since 3.12	17.1
Immutable	Cannot change after creation (`int`, `str`, `tuple`, `frozenset`)	2.2
Import system	Machinery that finds, loads, caches (`sys.modules`) and binds modules	8.2
In place	Changing the existing object rather than building a new one (`list.sort()` vs `sorted()`)	5.5
In-degree	Number of edges pointing into a node; Kahn's topological sort starts from nodes with in-degree 0	19.8
Index (pandas)	The row labels of a Series/DataFrame; operations align rows by these labels	18.4
Index (position)	An item's position in a sequence, counting from 0; negative indexes count from the end	4.4
Inheritance	A subclass reuses and extends a base class ("is-a")	10.4

Term	Meaning	Where
Instance	An object created from a class	10.1
Instance attribute	Attribute stored on one object (usually set in `__init__`)	10.1
Instance method	Ordinary method that receives the instance as `self`	10.1
Integer	Whole number; Python's `int` has unlimited size	2.5
Integration test	Test of several components working together	15.1
Interning (strings)	Reusing one object for equal strings (identifier-like literals, `sys.intern`)	17.3
Interpreter	Program that reads and runs code directly; `python` is CPython's interpreter	1.8
Interval	A range with a start and end (meeting times, number ranges)	19.15
Introspection	Examining objects at runtime (`type`, `dir`, `getattr`, `inspect`)	12.8
Invariance	Generic container types don't accept subtypes: `list[bool]` is not `list[int]`	13.3
Invariant	A condition that must always hold at a certain point (e.g. "the heap's smallest item is at index 0")	9.7
Iterable	Object that can return an iterator (`__iter__`): anything you can loop over	11.1
Iterator	Object producing items one at a time with `__next__`; single-pass	11.1
itertools	Standard module of lazy iterator building blocks	11.5
JIT (just-in-time) compiler	Compiles hot code to machine code while the program runs (PyPy, numba; experimental in CPython 3.13+)	17.7
Josephus problem	Classic puzzle: people in a circle, every k-th is removed — who survives?	19.18
JSON	Text data format; `json` module; safe and portable, limited types	9.11
Jupyter	Browser-based notebooks mixing code, output, charts and text; popular for data work	1.6
Kahn's algorithm	Topological sort that repeatedly removes nodes with in-degree 0 using a queue	19.8
KDF (key-derivation function)	Deliberately slow, salted hash for storing passwords (`hashlib.scrypt`, `pbkdf2_hmac`)	14.9
Key function	Function passed as `key=` that maps each item to the value used for sorting/min/max	5.7
Keyword	Reserved word of the language (`if`, `def`, `class`…)	1.9
Keyword argument	Argument passed by name (`f(x=1)`)	7.2
Keyword-only parameter	Parameter after `*` or `*args` that must be passed by name	7.2
`**kwargs`	Parameter collecting extra keyword arguments into a dict	7.2
`lambda`	Anonymous one-expression function	7.5
Late binding	Closures look up variables when called, not when created	7.4
Lazy deletion	Leaving stale heap entries in place and skipping them when they reach the top	19.5
Lazy evaluation	Computing values only when requested (generators, `range`, `map`)	11.4
LBYL	"Look before you leap": check conditions before acting	9.5

Term	Meaning	Where
LEGB	Name lookup order: Local, Enclosing, Global, Built-in	7.3
Library / framework	Library: code you call; framework: code that calls yours (Django, pytest)	1.3
LIFO / FIFO	Last-in-first-out (stack) / first-in-first-out (queue) order	6.9
Linked list	Nodes each pointing to the next; built with small classes in Python	19.7
Linter	Tool that flags bugs and style problems without running code (Ruff, Flake8)	1.6
list	Mutable, ordered sequence of any objects (dynamic array)	5.2
`Literal`	Type hint restricting a value to specific constants	13.10
Literal (value)	A value written directly in code: `42`, `"hi"`, `[1, 2]`, `{"a": 1}`	2.4
Load factor	How full a hash table is; CPython resizes a dict at about 2/3 full to keep lookups fast	6.2
Lock / mutex	"Mutual exclusion" synchronisation primitive: only one holder (thread) at a time may enter a critical section	16.4
Lock file	File pinning exact versions of every dependency for reproducible installs	8.8
Log level	Severity of a log message: DEBUG < INFO < WARNING < ERROR < CRITICAL	14.4
Logger / Handler / Formatter	logging's named source / output destination / message layout	14.4
LogRecord	Object holding one log event (message, level, time, source) that handlers format and output	14.4
Lomuto partition	Simple quicksort partition that sweeps once, moving items smaller than the pivot to the left	19.17
Loop control	`break` (leave the loop), `continue` (next iteration) and `pass` (do nothing)	3.8
Lowest common ancestor (LCA)	The deepest node that is an ancestor of two given nodes in a tree	19.7
`lru_cache`	Memoising decorator with a size limit, evicting least-recently-used entries	7.6
`map` / `filter` / `reduce`	Apply a function to each item / keep items passing a test / fold items into one value	11.7
Mapping	Object that maps keys to values (`dict`, `ChainMap`, `MappingProxyType`)	2.4
`match` statement	Structural pattern matching on a subject's shape and values (3.10+)	3.4
Matrix	Two-dimensional grid of numbers (rows × columns); a 2-D NumPy array or a list of lists	18.3
Max-heap trick	`heapq` is a min-heap only, so push negated values to get the largest item first	19.5
Memoization	Caching a function's results by its arguments	7.7
Memory address	Location of an object in memory; CPython's `id(x)` returns it	17.1
merge (pandas)	SQL-style join of two DataFrames on key columns	18.8
Merge sort	Divide-and-conquer sort: split in half, sort each, merge; O(n log n) and stable	19.17
Metaclass	The class of a class (default `type`); controls class creation	12.6
Method	Function defined in a class and called on its instances	10.1
Mixin	Small class adding one capability through multiple inheritance	10.6

Term	Meaning	Where
Mock	Test double that records calls and returns configured values	15.5
Module	A `.py` file whose names can be imported	8.1
Mojibake	Garbled text produced by decoding bytes with the wrong encoding	4.9
Monkey patching	Replacing attributes of modules/classes at runtime	12.7
Monotonic clock	Clock that never goes backwards (`time.monotonic`, `perf_counter`) — correct for timeouts and durations	14.2
Monotonic stack / deque	Stack (or deque) kept in sorted order: "next greater/smaller" in O(n); the deque version also drops items leaving a window — sliding-window max/min in O(n)	19.4
MRO (method resolution order)	Order Python searches classes for attributes, computed by C3 linearisation	10.5
MST (minimum spanning tree)	Cheapest set of edges connecting all nodes of a weighted graph; Kruskal's algorithm uses union-find	19.9
Multi-paradigm	Supports several programming styles: procedural, object-oriented and functional	1.2
multiprocessing	Running work in separate processes, each with its own interpreter and GIL	16.7
Mutable	Can be changed in place (`list`, `dict`, `set`)	2.2
Mutable default argument	Default like `[]` created once and shared by all calls — use `None`	7.2
Mutation testing	Deliberately changing code (`<` → `<=`) to check that some test fails	15.6
mypy	Static type checker for Python type hints	13.13
mypyc	Compiler that turns type-annotated Python modules into C extensions	17.7
Naive datetime	A `datetime` without time-zone information	14.1
Name mangling	`__attr` inside a class is renamed to `_Class__attr` to avoid subclass clashes	10.9
namedtuple	Tuple subclass with named fields	5.13
Namespace	Mapping from names to objects (module globals, a function's locals…)	7.3
Namespace package	Package directory without `__init__.py`, possibly spread over several folders	8.3
NaN	"Not a number": float value for undefined results; pandas uses it (and `NA`) for missing data; `NaN != NaN`	18.6
Narrowing	A type checker refining a union after a check like `is not None`	13.4
ndarray	NumPy's typed, contiguous, n-dimensional array	18.1
Negative infinity	`float("-inf")`, smaller than every number; `//` rounds toward it	2.5
Nested dictionary	Dict whose values are dicts — a natural fit for JSON-like hierarchical data	6.3
`NewType`	Creates a distinct type for checkers with zero runtime cost	13.10
Nominal typing	Compatibility decided by declared inheritance (class names) rather than by available methods	13.8
Non-data descriptor	Descriptor with only `__get__` (e.g. functions); the instance `__dict__` overrides it	12.4
`None`	The single "no value" object; functions without `return` give it	2.4

Term	Meaning	Where
`nonlocal`	Statement letting an inner function rebind a variable of its enclosing function	7.3
Normalization (Unicode)	Converting equivalent character sequences to one form (NFC/NFD)	4.9
`NotImplemented`	Value an operator dunder returns to say "I can't handle this type" so Python tries the other operand	10.3
numba	JIT compiler that speeds up numeric Python functions with a decorator	17.7
Numeric tower	Ordering `bool` → `int` → `float` → `complex`: mixed arithmetic converts to the wider type	2.7
NumPy / pandas / matplotlib	Libraries for numeric arrays / labelled tables / charts — the core data stack	18.1
Object	Any value in Python: has identity, type and value	17.1
Object-oriented programming (OOP)	Organising code into classes that bundle data with the methods that act on it	10.1
Open addressing	Hash-collision strategy that probes other slots in the same table	6.2
Operand	A value an operator acts on (`2` and `3` in `2 + 3`)	2.8
Operator overloading	Defining dunder methods so operators work on your types	10.3
Operator precedence	Which operators bind first (`*` before `+`); use parentheses when unsure	2.8
Optimal substructure	An optimal answer is built from optimal answers to subproblems — needed for DP and greedy	19.10
OrderedDict	Dict with `move_to_end` and order-sensitive equality; handy for LRU caches	6.9
Overflow	A value exceeding what a fixed-size type can hold; Python `int`s never overflow, floats become `inf`	2.5
Overlapping subproblems	The same smaller problems recur many times — caching them is what makes DP fast	19.10
Override	Redefining an inherited method in a subclass	10.4
Package	Directory of modules importable as a unit	8.3
Parallelism	Literally running several computations at the same instant on multiple cores	16.1
Parameter	Name in a function definition that receives an argument	7.1
`ParamSpec`	Type-hint variable capturing a function's full parameter list (for decorators)	13.7
Parametrize	`@pytest.mark.parametrize`: run one test with many inputs	15.4
Parquet	Columnar, compressed file format that keeps dtypes; fast with pandas	18.4
`partial`	`functools.partial`: new callable with some arguments pre-filled	7.6
Partition	Rearranging items around a pivot: smaller to one side, larger to the other	19.17
PATH	Environment variable listing folders the shell searches for commands such as `python`	1.4
Path compression	Union-find optimisation: point nodes straight at the root while finding it	19.9
pathlib	Object-oriented file-system paths (`Path("a") / "b.txt"`)	9.10
pdb	Python's built-in command-line debugger	15.11
PEP	Python Enhancement Proposal — design documents for the language	1.2

Term	Meaning	Where
PEP 8	Python's style guide	1.11
PEP 20 (Zen of Python)	Aphorisms describing Python's design philosophy (`import this`)	1.11
pickle	Serialises Python objects to bytes; unsafe to load from untrusted sources	9.11
Pin (version)	Fixing a dependency to one exact version (`requests==2.32.3`) for reproducible installs	8.8
pip	The standard package installer (`python -m pip install …`)	8.7
Pipeline	Chain of stages where each one's output feeds the next (often generators)	11.2
pipx	Installs Python command-line tools, each in its own isolated environment	8.7
pivot_table / melt	pandas reshaping: long → wide summary / wide → long	18.9
Placeholder	Marker filled in later: `?` in SQL, `{}` in format strings, `%s` in logging	14.11
Poetry	Tool for managing dependencies, virtual environments and packaging (alternative to uv)	8.8
Positional-only parameter	Parameter before `/` that can't be passed by keyword	7.2
Pre-emptive multitasking	The OS can pause a thread at any moment to run another — why threads need locks	16.10
Prefix sum	Running totals that give any range sum in O(1)	19.2
Priority queue	Queue that always serves the smallest (most urgent) item next — `heapq`	6.10
Process	A running program with its own memory; processes don't share Python objects	16.7
Producer–consumer	Pattern where producers put work on a queue and consumers take it	16.5
Profiling	Measuring where a program spends time or memory	17.6
Propagation (exception)	An unhandled exception travels up the call stack until some caller catches it	9.2
Propagation (logging)	A log record passes up to parent loggers' handlers; can cause duplicate output	14.4
`property`	Decorator turning methods into a managed attribute (getter/setter)	10.1
Property-based testing	Testing general properties over many generated inputs	15.9
`Protocol`	Structural interface for type checkers — match by methods, not inheritance	13.8
Pseudo-random	Numbers from a deterministic algorithm that look random; repeatable from a seed	14.7
Pure function	Result depends only on its arguments and it has no side effects — safe to cache	7.6
py-spy / scalene	Sampling profilers that measure a running program with very low overhead	17.6
pybind11 / PyO3	Tools for writing Python extension modules in C++ / Rust	17.7
Pydantic	Library validating and parsing data at runtime from type hints	13.14
PyObject	The C struct at the start of every CPython object: reference count + type pointer	17.1
PyPI	The Python Package Index, where `pip` downloads packages	8.7
pymalloc	CPython's allocator for small objects	17.2
PyPy	Alternative Python implementation with a JIT compiler	1.8

Term	Meaning	Where
`pyproject.toml`	Standard project file: metadata, dependencies, build system, tool config	8.8
pyright	Fast static type checker (also powers VS Code's Pylance)	13.13
pytest	The de-facto Python testing framework	15.4
Pythonic	Code that follows Python's idioms and style (clear, uses built-ins and comprehensions)	1.11
Queue (`queue.Queue`)	Thread-safe FIFO for passing work between threads; bounded with `maxsize`	16.5
Quickselect	Partition-based search for the k-th smallest/largest element, O(n) average	19.17
Quicksort	Divide-and-conquer sort that partitions around a pivot; O(n log n) average, O(n²) worst	19.17
Race condition	Bug where the result depends on the timing of threads/processes	16.4
Radix tree	Compressed trie where chains of single-child nodes are merged into one edge	19.13
`range`	Lazy, immutable sequence of integers (`range(start, stop, step)`, stop excluded)	3.6
Raw string	`r"…"` literal where backslashes are not escapes	4.5
Re-raise	Using a bare `raise` inside `except` to send the same exception onward	9.3
Recursion (base case, recursive case)	A function calling itself on a smaller input (the recursive case) until it reaches an input where it stops (the base case)	7.7
Recursion limit	Maximum call depth (default 1000), `sys.getrecursionlimit()`	7.7
Reentrant	Can be entered again while already in use (an `RLock`, a reusable context manager)	12.3
Reference count	Number of references to an object; freed when it reaches zero	17.2
Reference cycle	Objects that refer to each other, so reference counts never reach zero; the cyclic GC frees them	17.2
Reflected operator	`__radd__` etc., tried when the left operand doesn't support the operation	10.3
Regression test	Test added so a fixed bug can't silently return	15.1
Regular expression	Pattern language for matching text (`re` module)	4.10
Regular package	Package folder containing `__init__.py`	8.3
Relative import	Import relative to the current package (`from . import x`)	8.4
REPL	Read–eval–print loop: the interactive `>>>` prompt	1.5
`__repr__` / `__str__`	Developer-facing / user-facing text for an object	10.2
resample	pandas time-series grouping by calendar period (`"ME"`, `"W"`, `"D"`)	18.10
reveal_type	Special call that makes a type checker print the type it inferred for an expression	13.4
RLock	Re-entrant lock the same thread may acquire several times	16.11
Ruff	Very fast Rust-based linter and formatter for Python	1.11
Running median	Median kept up to date as numbers stream in, using two heaps	19.5
Salt	Random value mixed into a hash so equal inputs give different hashes	14.9
sdist	Source distribution: a `.tar.gz` of the project source that pip must build on install	8.9

Term	Meaning	Where
`secrets`	Module for cryptographically secure random tokens	14.7
`self`	The first parameter of an instance method — the object the method was called on	10.1
Semaphore	Lock allowing up to n holders at once	16.4
Sentinel	Special marker value, e.g. `None` default or an end-of-queue object	16.5
Series	pandas 1-D labelled array	18.4
set	Mutable, unordered collection of unique hashable items	6.6
Shadowing	A local name hiding an outer or built-in one (`list = [1]` hides the `list` type)	7.3
Shallow copy	New outer container sharing the same inner objects	5.8
Shebang	First line `#!/usr/bin/env python3` telling Unix which interpreter runs a script	1.5
Short-circuit evaluation	`and` / `or` stop as soon as the result is known	2.8
Side effect	Anything a function does besides returning a value: printing, writing files, mutating arguments	7.6
SIMD	"Single instruction, multiple data": CPU instructions processing several numbers at once — part of NumPy's speed	17.7
`singledispatch`	`functools` decorator choosing a function implementation by the first argument's type	7.6
Singleton	Object of which exactly one exists (`None`, `True`, `False`, `Ellipsis`) — compare with `is`	2.2
Slicing	`seq[start:stop:step]` — a new sequence (or view in NumPy)	4.4
Sliding window	Two indices bounding a contiguous range that moves in O(n)	19.2
`__slots__`	Class attribute fixing allowed instance attributes, removing `__dict__`	10.12
Small-int cache	CPython reuses the int objects −5 to 256	17.3
Soft keyword	Word that is a keyword only in context (`match`, `case`, `type`, `_`)	1.9
Space complexity	How much extra memory an algorithm needs as input grows (big-O)	19.1
Spy	Test double that records how it was called, while possibly passing calls through	15.5
SQL	Language for querying relational databases (`SELECT … FROM … WHERE …`)	14.11
SQL injection	Attack where user input is pasted into SQL text and changes the query — prevented by `?` placeholders	14.11
sqlite3	Standard-library interface to the embedded SQLite database	14.11
src layout	Project layout with code under `src/pkg/` so tests use the installed package	8.9
Stable sort	Equal keys keep their original relative order (Timsort is stable)	5.7
Stack	LIFO structure: push and pop at the same end (a Python `list`)	19.4
Standard library	Modules shipped with Python ("batteries included")	8.1
Standard output (stdout)	The stream `print` writes to — normally the terminal; `stderr` is the separate error stream	1.7
Start method	How `multiprocessing` creates children: `fork`, `spawn` or `forkserver`	16.7

Term	Meaning	Where
Static typing	Checking types before the program runs (mypy, pyright) rather than at run time	13.1
`staticmethod`	Method with no implicit first argument; a plain function in the class namespace	10.1
Steering Council	Five-person group, elected by core developers, that governs Python's development	1.2
StopIteration	Exception an iterator raises from `__next__` to signal it has no more items	11.1
str	Immutable sequence of Unicode code points	4.1
Strong typing	No silent conversion between unrelated types (`"1" + 1` fails)	2.3
Structural typing	Compatibility decided by available methods/attributes, not by class name	13.8
Structured concurrency	Tasks started in a scope must finish (or be cancelled) before the scope exits (`asyncio.TaskGroup`)	16.9
Structured logging	Log records as key–value data (often JSON) instead of free text, so tools can search them	14.4
Stub	Test double returning canned answers	15.5
Stub file (`.pyi`)	File with only type signatures for a module	13.13
Subinterpreter	Separate Python interpreter inside the same process, which can have its own GIL (3.12+)	16.6
subprocess	Module for running external commands (`subprocess.run([...])`)	14.6
Substring	A contiguous part of a string	4.3
`super()`	Proxy to the next class in the MRO, used to call overridden methods	10.4
SUT (system under test)	The code a test is exercising	15.1
Sweep line	Turning intervals into +1/−1 events sorted by time and keeping a running count	19.15
Switch interval	How long a thread may hold the GIL before being asked to release it (default 5 ms)	16.6
Syntax error	Code that breaks the language's grammar; reported before any of it runs	9.1
`sys.modules`	Cache of already-imported modules	8.2
`sys.path`	List of directories searched for imports	8.2
t-string	Template string literal `t"…"` (3.14) producing a `Template` object instead of a `str`	4.6
Tail-call optimisation	Reusing the frame when a function's last action is a call; CPython doesn't do it	7.7
Task (asyncio)	Wrapper that schedules a coroutine on the event loop to run concurrently (`create_task`)	16.9
TaskGroup	asyncio structured concurrency: runs tasks and cancels siblings on failure (3.11+)	16.9
TDD (test-driven development)	Red → green → refactor: write a failing test first	15.8
tempfile	Module creating temporary files/directories that clean themselves up	9.10
Terminal / shell	Text window where you type commands (Terminal, PowerShell) / the program interpreting them (bash, zsh)	1.5

Term	Meaning	Where
Test double	Stand-in for a real dependency in tests: dummy, stub, spy, mock, fake	15.5
Test suite	All the tests of a project, run together	15.1
TestPyPI	Separate practice copy of PyPI for trying uploads safely	8.9
Text mode	Default file mode: reads/writes `str`, decoding/encoding with the given encoding	9.9
Thread	Separate flow of execution sharing the process's memory	16.3
Thread-local data	Value where each thread sees its own copy (`threading.local()`)	16.3
`timedelta`	`datetime` type for a duration (`timedelta(days=1)`)	14.1
timeit	Module for timing small snippets accurately	17.6
Timsort	Python's stable, adaptive merge/insertion sort, O(n log n)	5.7
Token	Smallest meaningful piece of source code (name, number, operator); also a secret string such as an API key	1.8
TOML	Simple configuration file format used by `pyproject.toml`; read with `tomllib`	8.8
Top-down / bottom-up DP (tabulation)	Recursion with memoisation / tabulation: iteratively filling a table from the smallest subproblems upwards	19.10
Top-k	Finding the k largest/smallest items, typically with a size-k heap in O(n log k)	19.5
Topological sort	Ordering of a DAG's nodes so every edge points forward	19.8
tottime / cumtime	cProfile columns: time inside a function itself / including everything it calls	17.6
tracemalloc	Standard module tracing memory allocations by line	17.6
Traceback	Report of the call stack when an exception is not handled	15.10
Transaction	Group of database changes applied all together or not at all (commit / rollback)	14.11
Transpose	Flipping a matrix over its diagonal so rows become columns (`a.T`, `zip(*m)`)	19.18
Trie	Prefix tree storing strings letter by letter; insert, search and prefix checks are O(word length)	19.13
True division	`/`, which always returns a float (`7 / 2 == 3.5`)	2.5
Trusted Publishing	Uploading to PyPI from CI with short-lived credentials instead of a stored token	8.9
try / except / else / finally	Exception-handling statement; `else` on success, `finally` always	9.2
tuple	Immutable ordered sequence; hashable if its items are	5.9
Tuple packing	Commas create a tuple: `t = 1, 2`	5.9
Two pointers	Two indices moving through data to avoid nested loops	19.2
Two's complement	How computers store negative integers in binary; Python mimics it for bitwise ops (`~x == -x - 1`)	19.12
Type alias	Name for a type expression (`type Vector = list[float]`, 3.12)	13.12

Term	Meaning	Where
Type checker	Tool that reads type hints and reports mismatches without running code (mypy, pyright)	13.1
Type code	One-letter code fixing the element type of an `array.array` (`"i"`, `"d"`)	5.1
Type conversion	Changing a value's type (`int("3")`); implicit only within the numeric tower	2.7
Type inference	A checker working out a type itself from the code (`x = 1` → `int`)	13.2
`type: ignore`	Comment silencing a type-checker error on one line	13.13
TypedDict	Type hint for dicts with a fixed set of typed keys	13.9
typeshed	Collection of stub files describing the standard library and popular packages for type checkers	13.13
TypeVar	Placeholder type for generic functions/classes	13.6
ufunc	NumPy universal function operating element-wise in C (`np.sqrt`, `+`)	18.1
Unicode	Standard assigning a number (code point) to every character	4.9
Union by size	Union-find optimisation: attach the smaller tree under the larger one's root	19.9
Union type / `Optional[X]`	`A | B`: a value that may be either type; `Optional[X]` means `X | None`	13.4
Union-Find (DSU)	Structure tracking merging groups with near-O(1) find/union	19.9
Unit test	Fast test of one small piece in isolation	15.1
unittest	Standard-library xUnit-style testing framework	15.3
`unittest.mock`	Standard library for mocks and `patch`	15.5
Unpacking / star-unpacking	Assigning an iterable's items to several names (`a, b = xs`); `*` gathers "the rest" (`first, *rest = xs`) or spreads an iterable (`f(*xs)`, `[*a, *b]`)	5.10
URL	Web address (`https://host/path?query`); parse with `urllib.parse`	14.12
UTC	Coordinated Universal Time — the time-zone-free reference for storing timestamps	14.1
UTF-8	Variable-length Unicode encoding, 1–4 bytes per character; the default to use	4.9
uuid	Module generating universally unique identifiers	14.9
uv	Fast tool managing Python versions, venvs, dependencies and lock files	8.8
Validation	Checking that input has the expected shape and values before using it (pydantic at boundaries)	13.14
Variable	A name bound to an object; in Python it is a label, not a box	2.1
Vectorisation	Operating on whole arrays in compiled code instead of Python loops	18.1
Version specifier	Rule for allowed versions: `==2.1`, `>=2.1`, `<3`, `~=2.1`	8.8
View (NumPy)	Array sharing memory with another (e.g. a slice)	18.1
Virtual environment (venv)	Isolated per-project interpreter environment and package folder	8.7
Virtual machine (CPython)	The bytecode interpreter loop that executes compiled code	1.8
Wall time	Real elapsed clock time, including waiting; compare with CPU time	16.2
Walrus operator	`:=` assigns inside an expression (3.8+)	2.8

Term	Meaning	Where
Warning	Non-fatal message from the `warnings` module (e.g. `DeprecationWarning`) — not an exception by default	9.2
Weak reference	Reference that doesn't keep an object alive (`weakref`)	17.2
Wheel	Pre-built package archive (`.whl`) that installs without building	8.9
Wide / long format	Table with one column per variable or period / one row per observation; convert with `pivot_table` and `melt`	18.9
Wildcard pattern	`case _:` — matches anything without binding	3.4
`with` statement	Runs a block inside a context manager's setup and guaranteed cleanup	9.8
Worker	Thread or process in a pool that takes jobs and runs them	16.8
Wrapper	Inner function a decorator returns; it runs extra code around the original call	12.1
`yield`	Produces a value from a generator and pauses it	11.2
`yield from`	Delegates to a sub-generator/iterator	11.3
`zip`	Pairs items from several iterables, stopping at the shortest (`strict=True` to check)	3.6
zoneinfo	Standard-library IANA time zones (`ZoneInfo("Asia/Kolkata")`)	14.1

Chapter TL;DR

- Use the sheets in 21.1–21.19 as a quick reminder; follow the **§** references for full explanations, examples and pitfalls.
- 21.20 maps interview problem signals to patterns and lists the gotchas that cost the most points.
- 21.21 answers "what should I reach for?" in one table.
- The glossary defines 570+ terms in plain words and points to where each is taught.